

Apple AirPods 4 with Active Noise Cancellation

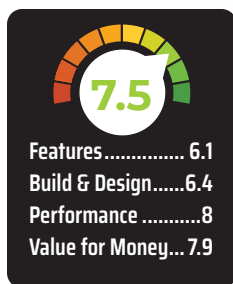
Best in class, but not otherwise

At their Glowtime Event in September, Apple unveiled their latest lineup of iPhones, their new Apple Watch Series 10 and the refreshed Apple AirPods 4, which now come with ANC. The launch event had a mixed bag of reactions coming from the fans. Even the Apple fanboys were in split minds about the new launches, especially the AirPods 4 with ANC. They are packing the new H2 headphone chip and a price tag of ₹17,900, which pits them against some of the best offerings from competitors outside the Apple ecosystem.

BUILD AND DESIGN

The design of the Apple AirPods 4 is not much of a departure from that of the other earbuds in Apple's lineup. The case has a familiar feel to it, though much narrower now. Out of the box, the case looks beautiful and is a treat to the eyes with its monochrome white finish and a nice metal accent on the hinge at the back. Apple has also done away with the paring button on these in-ear earphones, which eliminates a place where, over time, there was scope for dust and gunk to get caught in. So either plop them in a case or use them with utmost care. The case has a nice heft to it and, in typical AirPods fashion, is fairly easy to open. Kudos to Apple.

Now, coming to my second gripe with the design of the Apple AirPods 4. The design of the earbuds. Apple has retained the overall form factor of the earbuds, but instead of going with an in-ear design, they opted for a half-in-ear design, eliminating the driver duct. This means that the fit of the TWS will not be as comfort-



able or universally adaptable for many consumers.

This kind of earbud design is a pure gamble from brands in the modern age. Many manufacturers who use this design language tend to skip out on ANC because this kind of design is a hit and a miss for many, meaning that

users who do not get a good fit will have to settle with sub-par ANC.

That was the case with me. Neither I nor the folks whom I passed these TWS to got a great seal, meaning the ANC performance of the AirPods 4 suffered. More on that later. Even when I forced these earbuds into my ear, the fit got slightly better, but the seal was not what I would get with a pair of truly in-ear earphones, and my ear started hurting. I was also scared of these earbuds falling off most of the time.

FEATURES

In terms of features, the Apple AirPods 4 are packed with a solid feature set, which might not justify the price, but they do improve the day-to-day user experience of these TWS earphones. All the controls and customisations are tied into the Settings menu, which means that if you are planning to use these TWS earphones with a non-Apple device, then you won't be able to access any of them.

insert the Apple Ecosystem rant here
When in the ecosystem, you have access to a ton of well-implemented features.

PERFORMANCE

Let's start with the sound signature test of the Apple AirPods 4. The bass roll-off was what I expected to be the weak link when it came to the sound signature of the Apple AirPods because of their half-in-ear design. However, Apple has worked wonders with the sound signature of the AirPods 4.

They are far better than any other half-in-ear earbuds that I have listened to and definitely outperform one of the few half-in-ear earbuds to have hit the shelves in the last couple of years, the Nothing Ear (stick). The bass has a fair amount of presence in tracks, and bass-heavy tracks like Uptown Funk by Bruno Mars do not sound hollow. The mids come fairly close to the base-line reading of the Pink Noise, which represents a flat sound signature, and when you get to the highs, you have a fairly significant boost, signalling an overpowering presence of sibilants in the sound coming from the AirPods 4. However, in the real world, the boost manifests itself in increased clarity of the instruments falling in that range.

The typical response of these TWS earphones makes them a perfect fit for genres where the vocals shine through and metal and percussion instruments are also mastered with increased emphasis, including, but not limited to rock and metal. In terms of the staging, the lack of the perfect seal, which you would get from a pair of in-ear earphones, means that the sound stage of the Apple AirPods 4 is relatively more open than their in-ear cousins. And, thanks to the inclusion of Spatial Audio, the staging is immaculate if you keep it in fixed mode.